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Bill Junks Food - School dye ban

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California school kids could be waving goodbye to Flamin' Hot Cheetos, Doritos and Mountain Dew.

State lawmakers introduced a bill last week that would ban those and other heavily processed snacks in public schools — citing detrimental health effects.

"The science is complicated but the purpose of the bill is not," said bill author state Assembly member Jesse Gabriel at a press conference Tuesday. "This is about protecting our students from chemicals that have been proven to harm children and interfere with their ability to learn."

Assembly Bill 2316 would outlaw California schools from serving foods containing synthetic food dyes Red 40, Yellow 5, Yellow 6, Blue 1, Blue 2 and Green 3.

Such additives can be found in popular treats including M&Ms, Twinkies, Gatorade and, of course, Flamin' Hot Cheetos.

"This is not a food ban," Gabriel said, insisting the restriction only affected certain chemicals. "This is not banning Flamin' Hot Cheetos in California."

The bill would also ban titanium dioxide, a coloring agent often used in sunscreens, cosmetics, paints and plastics. The compound has been banned for use in food in the European Unionand other products containing it are required to have a warning about its potential side effects to children.

A 2021 California Environmental Protection Agency study found that "consumption of synthetic food dyes can result in hyperactivity and other neurobehavioral problems," Gabriel noted.

The father of three said the issue was "personal" to him as a person with ADHD who is parenting children with the same disorder.

His office claimed that the additives also have links to cancer and harm to the immune system.

The proposed law would still allow schools to sell foods containing the synthetic dyes, but only after 30 minutes past the end of the school day or events that take place off-campus.

The National Confectioners Association trade group slammed the legislation as part of a "sensationalistic agenda which is not based on facts and science."

The bill is expected to be heard in the Assembly Education Committee in the coming weeks.

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